The Elements of Reading

Five short chapters on pages, lines and returning.

CHAPTER 1

The Page

A page is a field of attention. Its margins are not empty space but the frame that lets the eye rest; its measure decides how far the eye must travel before it returns.

The Page — section 1

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CHAPTER 2

The Line

Good lines are neither too long nor too short. Between forty-five and seventy-five characters, the reader keeps their place without effort and the rhythm of the prose survives.

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CHAPTER 3

The Margin

Margins hold the thumb, the pencil and the pause. A generous margin is an invitation to slow down; a cramped one asks the reader to hurry.

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Plate I — The Measure

A landscape page, to prove the reader respects each page's own shape.

CHAPTER 4

The Return

Every reader leaves and every reader returns. A book remembers where it was opened; a good reading tool should remember just as faithfully.

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CHAPTER 5

The Quire

A quire is a gathering of folded sheets, the unit from which books are bound. It is the smallest whole thing a book is made of.

The Quire — section 1

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The Quire — section 2

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The Quire — section 3

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